Tibetan Treefrog Publishing ©

THE GREAT STRAVINSKY



ISSN 1544-1423

By David Ralph

I killed someone. It feels good to finally say it. Well, I didn't mean to and it wasn't just me alone; I guess I should say "The Great Stravinsky" killed someone. Yes, that sounds better: "The Great Stravinsky" killed Lisa Jacobs. Now you look a little confused. Maybe I should explain the beginning before the end.

**********END TEASER**********

Everyone knows that in high school one must find his or her place in order to survive. If you are athletic you hang out with the jocks and say things like: "Dude, that was a killer kegger last night; I got sooo wasted."

If you're good looking and have money but not much athletic ability you hang out with preppies and say things like: "Like wow, did you see how drunk that football player got last night at the kegger; he was like soooo wasted."

But if you look like and act like me then you hang out with what most would consider the nerds, geeks, outcasts, and/or whatever the popular joke word of the day was and you would say things like: "Did anyone know there was a kegger last night?" A question to which the retort consisted of blank stairs.

My friends were kind of an eclectic group but none of us would ever have been invited to a massive drunk fest. Theresa was my best friend, but she spoke as loud as a field mouse and spent hours working with computers, which didn't lend itself to the *social* scene. Shannon was hilarious, but her size and eating abilities made her the butt of most jokes. Shaun had enough acne on her face that it reminded one of the geological map of a coral reef and Amy was poor. I'm not talking about, Amy didn't have enough money to go to the movies or the mall kind of poor; I'm talking the kind of poor where her family would go without eating at night and she would have to shower each morning in the locker room before school. We all had something wrong with us. That's what made us a group. But even we, as the "messed up" group, had an outcast: Lisa Jacobs.

Look, every high school has its own cliques so I don't think I need to explain in great detail each and every one at mine…I think you get the picture here, my friends and I weren't exactly a part of the "in-crowd." We didn't really want to hang out with the

jocks and the preppies but we hated being treated like second-class citizens, so we decided to retaliate in the best way we knew how: write a newspaper.

We were passive-aggressive type people so this idea fit us perfectly. The idea was to write stories about all the people in school whether we hated them or liked them. It was only natural that I would become the editor. Theresa, would format the stories and print. Shannon, Shaun, and Amy were the field reporters all doing what they do best: blending in to the putrid walls of our high school to overhear *the dirt*. But first we needed a title. We thought of calling it "The Outsider" but that was almost cliché. Then "Chunky Monkey" but that didn't fit the whole group. "Whistler," "Stupid News to Use," "Extra, Extra" all sorts of titles were thrown around. Then, at a lovely school cafeteria lunch of cardboard shaped chicken patties, instant mash potatoes, and corn bits, Theresa muttered out a word that no one could understand but everyone heard as: Stravinsky.

The name didn't make any sense but it was interesting and fun to say: Stravinsky. You could say it sexy: Stravinsky. Or you could say it like an angry Russian mobster: Stravinsky. Or you could make it seem grand: Stravinsky. We all preferred the grand version so with some careful editing on my part we had our paper: "The Great Stravinsky."

In one week's time we had enough stories to write a full-fledge paper. As editor it was tough to decide what should go in and what needed to be held back. We had all sorts of *dirt* ranging from "Michael Davis will sell you answers to advanced algebra homework" to "Mrs. Haggleman actually isn't as mean as she pretends to be." Everything was great, but I decided to cut right to the heart of our little publication with a front-page shocker: "Tina Newman Loses Virginity." Amy overheard the conversation in the locker room. Supposedly Tina didn't want to do it but gave in to her boyfriend because she loved him and thought that he was the "one" even though she's only a Junior blah, blah, blah classic teenage hormone stuff but it made a great story because Tina was the goody-goody type that lead a local youth group and preached to everyone about abstinence.

We knew that this kind of information could get us in deep trouble so we left each article nameless and anonymously left a copy in all 203 lockers in our school. Before lunch occurred chaos was in progress. Student's that had been written about were in hysterics and student's that weren't written about were dying laughing. Tina Newman was called out of first hour American Studies and didn't return. At the end of the day principal pear-pants (he was shaped like a pear) came on the intercom to announce that those responsible for writing "The Great Stravinsky" would be caught and punished to the highest degree.

I remember feeling butterflies, no, more like fruit bats, flying around in my stomach, but I didn't know if it was because I was afraid of being caught or if it was because finally I was involved in something others in the school could see. As a group we decided that we needed to keep going with the paper. It was harmless fun. But we

also decided that we could tone the gossip down a tad, so that in the event we were caught we wouldn't get into too much trouble.

"The Great Stravinsky" volume two came out only a week after the first. This time we paid extra attention to not being caught as we placed them in the 203 lockers. We even included an article about ourselves as the "loser" table at lunch as to not make us prime suspects. This paper wasn't as sensationalized as the first, but did contain lovely articles on Dexter who would buy you alcohol because he was a senior with a great fake I.D. A "Great Debate" column discussing the vital topic of who was the cuter senior boy: Brad May or Joshua Frost and even a joke column with light-hearted jokes like "What do you call Santa's Helpers? Subordinate Clauses."

Everyone seemed to like this volume. "The Great Stravinsky" was the talk of the school. And we weren't being threatened anymore over the intercom by principal pear-pants so we decided to make a few more publications, eight in fact, but then we must have gotten sloppy.

Lisa Jacobs handed me a piece of paper in Honors English class. At the top was scribbled, "Wanna Be A Great Stravinsky." I slowly looked over my glasses at her and briefly made eye contact. She knew that I knew what she knew. I quickly read the brief note about how Lisa Jacobs wanted to be in our group and then folded it up, forced a smile on my face, and placed it in my massive literature textbook.

We now had a tough decision to make. We could let Lisa Jacobs into our group or face the fact that we would be caught. When you're a teenager your brain doesn't work at full capacity for some reason. You can't just step back, look at the big picture, and realize how big of a fool you're being, but we were teenagers and the decision we made will be with me for the rest of my life.

My logic told me that if we published an article about Lisa on the front page, and not just any article but a really juicy one, then if she tried to rat us out we could deny it and say that she was just mad about an article and wanted to get even with someone. This way we could keep our secretive social celebrity status going and we wouldn't have to hang out with Lisa Jacobs.

Shaun dropped the bomb of bombs for this story. Shaun used to be friends with Lisa Jacobs back in Junior High but then something happened one night that ended that relationship in a hurry. Lisa tried to kiss Shaun. And not like a friend kiss but like a full-fledged-want-to-make-you-my-steady-girl-friend kind of kiss. In our small town the word "gay" was used as a cruel or stupid euphemism; you know, like "this homework is so gay" or "stop sitting so close to me that's gay!?" We had never actually used the word to describe one amongst us.

We always knew that Lisa was different but we couldn't quite put our finger on it. I guess subconsciously we knew. And I guess even more subconsciously we were trained to despise it. While our group was secluded from everyone else Lisa Jacobs was even secluded from us: she sat alone at lunch, sat in the back of the room in class, walked

alone in the hallway, walked home without friends to talk to, share with, or complain to. She lived a singular, solitary life, and we, in our stupid teenage minds, decided to exploit that.

The headline on the front page of "The Great Stravinsky" volume eleven read "Lisa Jacobs Loves Girls." We took Shaun's one little tid-bit from Junior High and made it into a full-fledged story on how gay Lisa Jacobs was. We didn't know if it was true or not; the truth is it didn't matter. Before our article, Lisa was solitary but left alone; after our article Lisa was the center of everyone's scorn. Like I said, in a small town being gay was just something that you didn't do.

We thought about turning ourselves in, but the damage was already done and again in our teenage brains we just wanted to save our own necks. We decided not to publish anymore. The whole point of the Lisa Jacobs article was so that we could keep publishing but how could we after…

A week before we were to graduate and three weeks after the last "The Great Stravinsky" publication Lisa Jacobs committed suicide. According to the local paper there wasn't a note left behind just grieving parents wondering why. In my literature textbook sat the folded note Lisa gave me. This was her suicide note. It was her last chance of reaching out to someone…anyone. We didn't listen. We were too self-absorbed, too stupid and selfish to pay attention.

I killed someone. "The Great Stravinsky" killed Lisa Jacobs. It does feel good to finally tell the story and very soon I'll have to face the consequences of my words. The consequences of, "The Great Stravinsky".

Tibetan Treefrog Publishing
111 N Eddy
Fort Scott, KS 66701
Copyright 2008